A vulnerability in municipal software could theoretically be linked to power, water or transport systems. What worries governments is not one exploit but the possibility of multiple systems being probed and disrupted together. Munjal Kamdar, partner, cyber-strategy of Deloitte, frames the issue through "discovery and exploitation". Discovery is identifying vulnerabilities; exploitation is weaponising them. Historically, there was often a lag between the two. Now, that lag is collapsing. "With models like Mythos, this timeline from a few days could shrink to just a few hours," he says. Cybersecurity, in effect, becomes a race against time.

India's Vulnerabilities

If there is one country that embodies the promise and the risk of Mythos, it is India. Its financial system is vast and deeply software-driven. Banking deposits stand at Rs 251.9 lakh crore; mutual fund assets at Rs 73.7 lakh crore. UPI now has 500 million active users processing 22.6 billion transactions monthly. Few countries have digital financial infrastructure at this scale. But scale creates exposure. "Banking is a highly regulated sector and is sitting on legacy infrastructure," says Kunal Nandwani, co-founder of uTrade Solutions. Some core systems still run on programming languages such as COBOL, dating back decades. Legacy infrastructure has long posed risks. "AI changes the speed, scale and sophistication with which those risks may be exploited," he points out.

Compounding this is the structure of modern finance itself. Banks no longer operate in silos. They sit within ecosystems of payment providers, fintechs, insurers, application programming interfaces (APIs) and third-party vendors. "More API integration increases the opportunity for cybercriminals to launch attacks because while banks are regulated entities that follow strict security principles, other financial institutions may not have them," says Verma of FSS. That is why experts see fintech firms and payment aggregators as particularly exposed. They may be used as entry points into larger banking networks. NBFCs, with heavy third-party dependence, face similar concerns. Neobanks add another layer of distributed risk.

Some industry voices argue that India's permissioned banking networks, where access is restricted to verified participants, and layered firewalls provide resilience. They may well do. But there are many who warn of the dangers. "Mythos has assembled a series of parallel agents and each of these agents can co-relate with the chain of security events and launch an agent within minutes," says Ramesh Lakshminarayanan, group head, IT, and chief information officer at HDFC Bank. "Therefore, all vulnerabilities on legacy applications—including zero-day vulnerabilities—can be picked up in a matter of minutes. "

Increasingly, the risk is not viewed as a breach problem, it is viewed as one of contagion. That is where India's digital public infrastructure enters the picture. UPI, Aadhaar and DigiLocker have transformed the economy. But their interdependence also means vulnerabilities in one area may ripple into others.



There is another anxiety. Some experts privately note that frontier defensive systems such as Glasswing-style capabilities may remain concentrated among top-tier global software players, while legacy-heavy institutions elsewhere face the threat without comparable access to cutting-edge defensive tools. That asymmetry matters. It raised a strategic concern among policymakers: if such frontier defensive tools remain concentrated among a handful of advanced